

What else to watch: *It Always Rains on a Sunday* (1947) ■ *Passport to Pimlico* (1949) ■ *Whisky Galore!* (1949) ■ *The Man in a White Suit* (1951) ■ *The Titfield Thunderbolt* (1953) ■ *The Ladykillers* (1955)



The charmingly selfish Sibella presents her marriage deal to Mazzini in his cell. Sibella is competing with Edith, the widow of one of Mazzini's victims, to marry him.

Here is director Robert Hamer's genius in having Guinness play all eight victims. Because the audience knows that when one Guinness character is bumped off, another will take his place, it never feels repelled by the murders, but rather remains in thrall to Price's charm and wills him on as he eliminates the obstacles to inheriting the title. A subplot shows Mazzini in a complex romantic relationship with

his materialistic childhood sweetheart Sibella (Joan Greenwood), who made the mistake of turning down the lowly Mazzini to marry the rich but very dull Lionel, only to see Mazzini rise to become a duke and fabulously rich, while Lionel descends into bankruptcy and suicide. Mazzini, having got away with the D'Ascoyne murders, is convicted of murdering Lionel,



The movie's title is taken from a poem by Alfred, Lord Tennyson: "Kind hearts are more than coronets, and simple faith than Norman blood."

the one death of which he's innocent. His only hope of escaping the hangman comes when Sibella hints that she might "find" Lionel's suicide note if Mazzini promises

to marry her. But even then, the movie has one more twist up its sleeve—a typically sardonic finale. Ealing movies were not always as sweetly innocent as their reputation suggests, and Hamer's movie was the perfect mix of the comic and the caustic. ■

“I shot an arrow in the air; she fell to earth in Berkeley Square.”

Louis Mazzini / Kind Hearts and Coronets